



RAFT
Rao Family Trust

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ABOUT US

The Rao Family Trust (RAFT) offers grants to nonprofits with a rigorous, evidence-based approach focused on measurable, sustainable results.

As a private trust, RAFT channels its resources in a structured, transparent, and purpose-driven manner to ensure that its philanthropic vision continues to inspire meaningful change for generations.

We are based in Pune, Maharashtra.

Vision

A compassionate, equitable, and sustainable world where every individual and ecosystem has the opportunity to thrive.

Mission

Creating enduring social and ecological impact through strategic, transparent, and intergenerational philanthropy.

OUR APPROACH

Our grantmaking is grounded in trust, simplicity and curiosity.

Through our grants, we support organisations to respond to community needs and scale proven models and frameworks. We also provide multi-year funding that helps organisations build capacity, strengthen sustainability and create lasting change.

MEET OUR TEAM

Dr. Priti Rao

Managing Trustee

A corporate leader, entrepreneur and philanthropist with a strong background in IT leadership and social enterprise. After senior roles at Infosys and L&T, she founded Pumpkin Patch Daycare to support working mothers, and leads Aatmaja Foundation — focused on empowering girls from disadvantaged backgrounds through STEM education.

Jay Rao

Trustee

Founder of Milestones, with expertise in early childhood development, care and education. Milestones has been associated with over 175 schools and daycare centres, providing guidance, solutions, and world-class equipment, teaching aids and books.

Dr. Pooja Rao

Trustee

A physician-scientist, entrepreneur and research leader working at the intersection of healthcare, AI and global innovation. Currently a Research Scientist at Google, Amsterdam, leading global AI research, clinical studies and regulatory approvals. She holds a medical degree and a PhD in Neuroscience from the Max Planck Research School, Germany.

Priyadarshini Gurav

Trustee

A dedicated social work professional with over a decade of experience in Medical and Psychiatric Social Work. She is deeply committed to empowering women through development focused workshops and initiatives.

OUR PILLARS OF GIVING

Education

- Enable professional education and quality learning for girls ensuring economic independence
- Transform girls into future leaders and changemakers
- Improve educational opportunities in remote communities

Biodiversity & Conservation

- Protect biodiversity, wildlife habitats, and critical ecosystems
- Support community-led conservation through science-based solutions
- Inspire environmental stewardship for a sustainable future

Livelihoods

- Drive women's economic empowerment
- Build market-relevant skills leading to meaningful careers and higher incomes
- Strengthen women's confidence, leadership in society

Tech for Good

- Apply technology and innovation to address pressing social challenges
- Accelerate the diffusion of technology to underserved communities
- Support scalable, sustainable solutions that expand access

Disability Inclusion

- Expand access to education, employment, and services
- Enable skills, livelihoods, and independence
- Promote dignity, inclusion, and participation

Geographic Focus: Primarily — Maharashtra, India

Our Current Projects in

EDUCATION



ENABLING OUR DAUGHTERS : AATMAJA FOUNDATION

Pune | Girls from socioeconomically disadvantaged backgrounds | Grant: 2015 – Ongoing

aatmaja.org

Through 4 strategic programs, Aatmaja Foundation builds confidence, life skills and professional capabilities to create empowered and self-reliant women.

Udaan Program

Long-term educational support guiding girls through scholarships, mentorship & skill-building to become independent professionals.

Aasha Program

Equips girls with job-ready vocational skills across healthcare, technology, hospitality & wellness for faster employment.

Girls in STEM

Builds girls' confidence and interest in STEM through hands-on workshops, expert talks, mentoring & industry exposure.

Multi Skill Foundation Course (MSFC)

Practical vocational training across engineering, electrical, plumbing & agriculture — building technical skills & career readiness.

IMPACT SNAPSHOT

500+

Girls supported

100+

From rural Maharashtra

120+

Employed / entrepreneurs

98%

STEM improvement

200+

Trained under MSFC

CREATING FIRST GENERATION LEARNERS :: AYANG TRUST

Majuli, Assam | Children from Mising Tribe, Assam | Grant: 2025 – 2029

thehummingbirdschool.in

The Hummingbird School, under Ayang Trust, operates at the intersection of education and resilience in the flood-affected communities of Majuli, which continue to grapple with poor connectivity, fragile infrastructure, and deep-rooted socio-economic challenges. The Hummingbird School has been committed to ensuring access to quality education for these children. The pedagogy and the curriculum of the school deviate from the conventional learning methods, emphasizing experiential learning, inquiry-driven and context-relevant learning. This has allowed the children to connect their education with their lived realities while developing their curiosity, creativity and critical thinking.

IMPACT

37

Students receive continued residential and educational support

1st

Generation learners from Mising tribal community

4+

Years of sustained support since 2025

Our Current Projects in

BIODIVERSITY & CONSERVATION



GUARDIANS OF THE GIANTS :: SAHYADRI SANKALP SOCIETY

Ratnagiri | Malabar Pied Hornbill, Great Hornbill, Malabar Grey Hornbill | Grant: 2025 – 2028

sahyadrisankalpsociety.org

The Western Ghats is home to three iconic Hornbill species. These birds are critical seed dispersers, shaping forest regeneration and structure. However, their survival is threatened by loss of nesting and fruiting trees, forest degradation and fragmentation and lack of public awareness. The project focuses on a landscape-level conservation approach emphasizing nest protection, habitat restoration and community involvement.

IMPACT

102

Nest sites identified

61

Active nests documented

100+

Monitored by community

5500+

Seeds collected

4000+

Seeds sown in a nursery

CATAPULTS TO CAMERAS :: HUMAN & ENVIRONMENT ALLIANCE LEAGUE

Jhargram, West Bengal | Boys from Hunting Communities & Wildlife | 2026 – 2027
healearth.in

In Southern West Bengal, over 40 mass hunting festivals are documented annually across seven districts — drawing up to 20,000 armed participants and killing thousands of wild animals in a single day. These are not subsistence hunts. They are organised bloodsport.

In these villages, boys are handed catapults as young as age three. By adolescence, participation in mass hunts is a rite of masculinity and belonging. The solution starts with children. When boys in these communities are given cameras, mentorship, and recognition, their relationship with nature shifts fundamentally.

Catapults to Cameras — a critically acclaimed documentary by wildlife filmmaker Ashwika Kapur and HEAL's field team — followed five adolescent boys who voluntarily gave up their catapults and became wildlife enthusiasts and conservation ambassadors. The film earned international recognition, turning a grassroots experiment into a global conversation. This project scales that model.

EXPECTED IMPACT

1 Mobile Field Library across 12 villages	12 Children trained in photography & wildlife observation	Kids' Nature Clubs formed in villages	12+ Workshops & screenings in hunting villages	1 District-level exhibition for public recognition
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Our Current Projects in

LIVELIHOODS



CLIMATE SMART AGRICULTURE :: MANNDESHI

Satara, Sangli, Solapur, Pune district, Maharashtra | Women farmers | 2026 – 2027

[manneshifoundation.org](http://mannadeshifoundation.org)

Farmers have largely relied on traditional practices, even though agriculture is a highly technical and scientific field. By focusing on soil, we intervene at the very beginning of the crop cycle, where the foundation of productivity is set.

The project aims to strengthen the capacity and resilience of 1,500 farmers by improving soil health knowledge, introducing climate-smart agricultural practices, and increasing access to emerging agricultural technologies. Through soil testing services, advanced courses on horticulture farming and knowledge sessions on agri-tech, artificial intelligence in agriculture, climate literacy, and scientific farming methods, the project will equip farmers with the tools and information needed to make data-driven decisions.

EXPECTED IMPACT

1500

women farmers Total
beneficiary count

1200

To be trained in scientific
agricultural, climate literacy
and AI

250

Will be provided with soil
testing

50

To be trained in advanced
horticulture farming

6

Exposure Visits To learn
best practices and meet
other farmers

ROOTS SHASHWAT VIKAS KENDRA :: GOKHALE INSTITUTE OF POLITICS & ECONOMICS

Mahad Taluka in Raigad district, Maharashtra | Tribal & marginalized communities | 2026 – 2027

gipe.ac.in

Mahad Taluka in Raigad district faces four compounding challenges: 1. Socio-Economic Vulnerability: Small farmers and landless labourers remain largely excluded from the formal economy 2. Ecological Degradation: Biodiversity loss and erosion of traditional ecological knowledge 3. Climate & Resource Stress: Growing water insecurity and soil degradation, worsened by poor waste management and inefficient agricultural practices 4. Institutional Gaps: Local Gram Panchayats lack the technical capacity to implement key mandates

The Shashwat Vikas Kendra will serve as a localised hub addressing these challenges across three pillars: Natural Resource Management, Livelihood Security and Village-level Governance

EXPECTED IMPACT

Reduced migration;
alternate livelihoods

Legal protection of bio-
resources & traditional
knowledge

Improved public health and
groundwater levels

Decentralized, data-driven
local governance

Women shift from passive
beneficiaries to active
participants

Our Current Projects in

TECHNOLOGY



PREVENTION OF AVOIDABLE BLINDNESS :: SHANTILAL SHANGHVI EYE INSTITUTE

M/E Ward, Mumbai, Maharashtra | Residents | 2026 – 2027
ssei.care/

Maharashtra's rate of blindness and visual impairment exceeds the national average. In Mumbai's M/E ward, one of the city's most densely populated slums, nearly 2% of residents are blind and 13% live with visual impairment, yet 66% of that blindness and 84% of that impairment is treatable.

The program takes a pocket-based approach, bringing awareness, community engagement and screening directly into neighborhoods, with at least six months of follow-up to build lasting eye-health habits. 'Sakhis', women from the community are trained on two cutting-edge portable tools: Remidio's split lamp for a thorough anterior eye exam, and a handheld fundus camera that delivers high-quality retinal screening in under a minute.

The goal is to screen and treat preventable causes of blindness — cataract, uncorrected refractive error, glaucoma, and diabetic retinopathy, while building a sustainable model through links to existing government schemes and strengthening the community's long-term access to and habits around eye care.

EXPECTED IMPACT



CENTER OF EXCELLENCE FOR CLEAN ENERGY & GREEN HYDROGEN :: VENTURE CENTER

Pune, Maharashtra | Incubated startups & ecosystem | 2025 – 2026

venturecenter.co.in

India's commitments to COP26 and UNFCCC include reducing GDP emissions intensity by 45% and achieving 50% non-fossil fuel energy capacity by 2030. To meet these goals, initiatives in Clean Energy (CE) and Green Hydrogen (GH2) are crucial for energy independence, reducing reliance on imports, and creating socio-economic benefits.

The Center for Clean Energy (CoE) and Green Hydrogen will focus on:

- Energy generation and new fuels: solar, wind, biomass and green hydrogen
- Energy storage: Batteries, supercapacitors and advanced technologies.
- End-use sectors: Mobility, industrial power and urban energy needs.

It will offer services and training programs to startups and stakeholders in the ecosystem. The project will support start-ups developing clean energy, sustainable mobility, environmental technologies, carbon management and circular economy solutions. The CoE is a significant step toward building a self-sufficient and innovative clean energy ecosystem in India.

EXPECTED IMPACT

60+

New startups to be incubated

1000+

New jobs will be created by incubated startups

50+

Events, workshops and hackathons to be organised

60+

Mentors and domain experts to be engaged

20+

New strategic partnerships to be established

15+

Startups to raise external funding

SOLAR PANEL INSTALLATIONS :: VENTURE CENTER

Pune, Maharashtra | Incubated startups | 2025 – 2026

venturecenter.co.in

Venture Centre has a goal of 100% renewal energy by 2030. Currently, ~20% is attained through renewable energy. To increase it to 50%, they need to install solar photovoltaic systems covering roughly 10,000 sq.ft of land space and producing 150 KWp of power.

Installing this solar panel system will replace 20-30% grid power usage, replacing conventional fossil fuels with renewable energy.

The annual savings generated through reduced electricity expenditure will be reinvested towards strengthening incubation programmes, startup support activities, and innovation infrastructure, thereby enhancing the long-term sustainability of the incubator.

EXPECTED IMPACT

45 kWp

Solar capacity to be installed

64,800 units

Power to be generated annually

8.10 Lakhs

Estimated annual savings

180 units/day

Average power to be generated



"Philanthropy can catalyze systemic change, fostering equity, equality, and resilience across communities, ecosystems, and our shared future.

I encourage you to use your voice, influence, and resources to help shape a more equitable and resilient future."

Get in Touch

contact@raft.org.in

www.raft.org.in

[linkedin.com/company/rao-family-trust](https://www.linkedin.com/company/rao-family-trust)